

Prairie Houses

Inspired by Frank Lloyd Wright's article 'A Home in a Prairie Town,' published in a 1901 *Ladies' Home Journal*, the term Prairie Houses or Prairie School has been applied to a certain style of dwelling mainly built in midwestern America during the late 19th and early 20th centuries. Architects include Wright himself, Walter Burley Griffin (1876–1937) and George W. Maher (1864–1926).

Solid in construction, Prairie Houses emphasize horizontal lines, with single storeys, low-pitched roofs and overhanging eaves, long bands of casement windows, central chimneys, open-plan interiors and minimal ornamentation. Made mainly with local materials, they integrate well with the landscape; timber is unstained and unpainted, and other materials are left as natural as possible. Although they never used the term 'Prairie House' themselves, the architects all believed that horizontal lines evoked and related to the native prairie landscape. Wright's most acclaimed 'Prairie School' buildings include the Robie House in Chicago (1909) and the Laura R. Gale House in Oak Park (opposite, 1908).

